

Chapter Eighteen

The Mercy of Not Knowing

Tomas survived the infection.

That was how Maya said it the next morning, standing barefoot in her kitchen with her hair loose around her face and a mug of coffee untouched between her hands.

Not “the fever went down.”

Not “the antibiotics worked.”

Not “he is stable.”

Survived.

The word entered the room heavily, without apology.

Nora sat at the table across from her. Adam had gone home just after sunrise to shower and change before work, though he had looked like a man who should not be trusted with stairs, let alone patients. Maya had slept for three hours on the couch. Nora had slept for one and woken with her cheek pressed to the kitchen table.

Everything smelled of stale coffee, cold pasta, and rain-damp coats.

“He made it through the night,” Maya said.

Nora nodded.

“I’m glad.”

Maya looked at her.

There were words behind her eyes. Nora could see them, but she did not reach.

That restraint had begun to feel like a muscle.

Weak.

Sore.

Usable.

Maya took a slow breath. “I was scared he wouldn’t.”

“I know.”

This time, the words did not mean stolen knowledge.

They meant listening.

Maya’s mouth trembled. “My mother kept saying he was fine. The doctors kept saying they were monitoring him. Adam kept standing in the hallway pretending not to be exhausted. Everyone was trying to be calm.”

“And you weren’t.”

“No.” Maya gave a small, broken laugh. “I was not.”

Nora held her mug with both hands.

“Do you want to tell me about it?”

Maya looked surprised by the question.

Not because Nora asked.

Because Nora had left room for no.

Maya glanced toward the living room, where the blanket she had slept under lay twisted across the couch.

“Not yet,” she said.

“Okay.”

The answer came easier this time.

Maya stared at her for a second, then looked down.

“I hate that I’m testing you.”

“I think you’re allowed.”

“I don’t want our friendship to become an exam.”

“Sisterhood,” Nora said quietly.

Maya looked up.

Nora swallowed. “You said friendship.”

Maya’s face changed, and the hurt that passed through it was immediate and unguarded.

“I didn’t mean—”

“I know.”

“No.” Maya stepped closer. “Nora, I didn’t mean it like that.”

The old Nora would have made the slip a trial. Would have held it up, turned it in the light, asked what it revealed. Friendship, not sisterhood. A demotion. A warning. Proof.

The new Nora still felt the wound.

But she also saw Maya’s exhaustion. The grayness beneath her eyes. The way grief made language less precise.

“I know,” Nora said again, and this time she let it be enough.

Maya’s eyes filled.

“I’m sorry.”

“It just hurt for a second.”

“I’m still your sister.”

Nora nodded.

Maya came around the table and hugged her from behind, arms loose around Nora’s shoulders.

Nora closed her eyes.

The pressure did not come.

Only Maya.

Warm.

Tired.

Here.

“I’m sorry,” Maya whispered into her hair.

“I know.”

Maya laughed weakly. “We say that too much.”

“We have limited emotional vocabulary under stress.”

“That sounds like something Adam would say.”

“He is infecting us.”

“Poorly timed word.”

Nora smiled.

Maya released her and sat again.

For the first time that morning, she drank the coffee, grimaced, and pushed it away.

“This is terrible.”

“You made it.”

“Tragedy has affected my gift.”

“You never had the gift.”

Maya narrowed her eyes. “I invited you into my home.”

“And I am honoring that intimacy with honesty.”

Maya laughed.

It was small, but real.

Then the laughter faded.

Her phone buzzed.

Both of them looked.

Maya picked it up. “Mom.”

Nora looked away immediately.

Not because she was not curious.

Because she was.

Maya answered. “Hi.”

Nora stood and began clearing cups from the table, giving Maya the illusion of privacy if not the full fact of it.

“Yes,” Maya said into the phone. “I slept.”

A pause.

“Mom.”

Another pause.

“No, she stayed. Nora stayed.”

Nora’s hands stilled at the sink.

She did not turn.

Maya’s voice softened. “Yes. She helped.”

The words touched Nora more than they should have.

Then Maya said, “No, don’t ask her that.”

Nora froze.

Maya looked toward her.

Their eyes met.

Nora understood immediately.

Lucia wanted to know about the night before. Maybe whether Nora had sensed something. Maybe whether Adam had told her. Maybe whether Maya had told her. The exact shape did not matter.

Someone was asking about Nora while Nora stood close enough to hear.

Maya said, “Mom, later.”

A pause.

“I know you’re scared.”

Nora gripped the edge of the sink.

Lucia’s fear reached her faintly through the phone, not as a jump, not as a pull, but as an ache in the air. A wife who had almost lost her husband in the night. A mother trying to keep her daughter upright. A woman realizing that Nora had somehow become part of their family’s crisis without anyone understanding how.

Maya listened for a moment.

Then she said, “I’ll ask her.”

Nora turned fully.

Maya lowered the phone from her ear and covered the microphone.

“She wants to know if you’ll come to the hospital today.”

Nora blinked.

“What?”

Maya’s expression was careful. “She said Dad asked. And she...”
Maya swallowed. “She said she wants to thank you for staying with me last night.”

Nora felt the request enter her.

Given.

Not taken.

Still, beneath it, fear stirred.

The hospital.

Lucia.

Tomas after infection.

Maya's family letting her closer.

The more doors opened willingly, the more Nora feared what might happen if one closed again.

"Do you want me there?" Nora asked.

Maya's face softened.

"Yes," she said. "But only if you want to come. Not because we asked."

Nora almost laughed.

"Those are hard to separate."

"I know."

Nora looked down at the sink full of cups and plates.

"I want to come," she said. "And I am scared that wanting to come is partly wanting to prove I can."

Maya nodded.

"That's honest."

"Is it still okay?"

Maya considered it.

Actually considered it.

That mattered.

"Yes," she said at last. "Because you said it out loud first."

Nora breathed out.

Maya returned to the call. "She'll come."

A pause.

"Yes, Mom. She eats."

Nora frowned.

Maya mouthed, Sorry.

Then, into the phone: “No, don’t bring crackers for her.”

Another pause.

“She heard that.”

Nora took the phone from Maya’s hand gently.

Maya looked startled but let her.

“Hi, Lucia,” Nora said.

There was a tiny silence.

Then Lucia’s voice came through, tired and warm. “Nora, sweetheart. You should eat something before the hospital. Hospitals steal strength.”

“I will.”

“And bring a sweater. The rooms are cold.”

“I will.”

“And thank you,” Lucia said, voice breaking slightly. “For last night.”

Nora closed her eyes.

She could say, I almost entered your grief without permission.

She could say, I only stayed out because Adam talked me down.

She could say, You are thanking me for not stealing from you.

Instead, she said the truth she could safely give.

“I’m glad Maya wasn’t alone.”

Lucia was quiet.

Then she said, “So am I.”

Nora gave the phone back.

Maya watched her with something unreadable in her face.

“What?” Nora asked.

“You sounded normal.”

Nora laughed. “Deep insult.”

“No. I mean...” Maya sat down slowly. “You sounded like family.”

The word moved through Nora with such force that she had to turn back to the sink.

She washed dishes for a minute too long.

Maya let her.

That afternoon, the hospital felt different.

Not softer.

Hospitals were never soft. But the place seemed less like a mouth waiting to swallow her and more like a building full of people trying, in imperfect rooms, to keep bodies attached to futures.

Nora arrived with Maya at two.

This time, she brought nothing.

No flowers.

No fruit.

No offering.

Only herself.

Lucia was in the hallway when they arrived, speaking to a nurse. She looked smaller than the day before, as if the night had taken an inch from her. When she saw Maya, she reached for her immediately. Maya went into her arms.

Nora stepped back.

Let them have the first embrace.

Lucia noticed.

After holding Maya, she turned to Nora and took both her hands.

“Thank you for coming.”

“Thank you for asking.”

Lucia’s eyes searched her face, but not unkindly.

“You look tired.”

“So does everyone.”

Lucia smiled faintly. “Then we are dressed correctly for the occasion.”

Inside the room, Tomas was awake.

Barely.

But awake.

His eyes opened when they entered, and his mouth moved into something like a smirk.

“No pears,” Nora said before he could speak.

Tomas’s expression shifted into approval.

“You learn.”

“I try.”

“You try loudly.”

Maya sat beside the bed and took his hand.

Nora stayed near the foot of the bed until Lucia pointed to a chair.

“Sit, sweetheart.”

Nora sat.

She listened as Tomas complained about a nurse who had “the bedside manner of a government form.” Lucia told him not to be rude. Maya told him being rude meant he was recovering. Tomas said recovery was too dramatic a word for his current situation, which he described as “moderately undead.”

Nora laughed.

So did Maya.

So did Lucia, though hers turned quickly into tears.

Tomas saw.

His face changed.

The room shifted around that small change.

There was fear beneath his humor. Nora did not need a jump to know it. It moved through the room like cold air under a door.

Tomas squeezed Lucia’s hand.

“Don’t start,” he said.

Lucia wiped her face. “I am allowed.”

“You are. But not while I am being charming.”

“You are never charming.”

“I am beloved.”

“You are tolerated.”

Maya covered her mouth, smiling and crying at once.

Nora sat still.

She wanted to hold the room together.

She wanted to make Lucia laugh again.

She wanted to ask Tomas if he was afraid.

She wanted to ask Maya if this was too much.

She did none of it.

She let the room be what it was.

Tomas looked at her suddenly.

“You are quiet today.”

Nora straightened. “Sorry.”

“I did not say it was bad.”

Nora closed her mouth.

Tomas studied her with tired eyes.

“You listen like a person holding a glass of water too full.”

Maya looked at her father. “That is weirdly accurate.”

Nora smiled faintly. “I’m trying not to spill.”

Tomas nodded.

“Good. But don’t forget to drink.”

The sentence was ridiculous.

It still felt profound because everyone was exhausted.

A doctor came in shortly after.

Nora stood immediately. “I can wait outside.”

Maya looked at her.

Lucia looked at Maya.

Tomas waved one hand weakly. “Stay unless they remove my dignity. Then leave before witnessing the crime.”

The doctor smiled politely, clearly unsure whether to laugh.

Nora looked at Maya. “Are you sure?”

Maya nodded. “Stay.”

So Nora stayed.

Not because she had forced herself into the medical conversation.

Because the people in the room had asked.

The doctor explained infection markers, antibiotics, monitoring, possible adjustments. Nora listened but did not memorize. She did not turn the words into a project. When questions came to her mind, she let them pass unless Maya or Lucia asked first.

Maya asked two.

Lucia asked one.

Tomas asked whether antibiotics came with better food.

The doctor said no.

Tomas declared this a systemic failure.

After the doctor left, Maya walked Nora to the vending machine.

“Did you understand all of that?” Maya asked.

“Some.”

“Enough to panic?”

“Yes.”

Maya smiled weakly. “But you didn’t.”

“No.”

“Teach me.”

Nora looked at her.

Maya leaned against the vending machine, arms crossed.

“I mean it. You’re panicking quietly. I can see it. But you’re not making me manage it. How?”

Nora considered lying.

Then didn't.

"I am imagining the panic as a dog."

Maya stared.

"A dog?"

"A badly trained dog."

"Oh my God."

"It barks at everything. It thinks every stranger is a murderer and every closed door is abandonment."

Maya's mouth twitched.

"So when it starts barking," Nora said, "I don't have to pretend there is no dog. But I also don't have to hand it a weapon."

Maya burst out laughing.

Too loud for the hallway.

A nurse glanced over.

Maya covered her mouth. "I'm sorry. That is the stupidest useful thing you have ever said."

"I accept that award."

Maya wiped her eyes. "My fear is not a dog."

"What is it?"

Maya thought.

"A clerk."

Nora blinked. "A clerk?"

"A very tired clerk with a clipboard, listing everything that might go wrong."

Nora laughed. "That is extremely you."

“I know. She has glasses.”

“Of course she does.”

“And she hates unplanned emotional events.”

“Then she must hate our lives.”

“She has filed many complaints.”

They laughed again.

Not because Tomas was better.

Not because anything had been solved.

Because for thirty seconds, fear had become ridiculous enough to survive.

When they returned to the room, Lucia had fallen asleep in the chair beside the bed, chin lowered to her chest. Tomas was watching her.

The expression on his face stopped Nora.

Love without performance.

Fear without jokes.

He looked at Lucia as if trying to memorize her while she was not watching.

Nora felt the room draw inward.

A pressure touched her eyes.

Soft.

Not demanding.

But there.

She inhaled sharply.

Maya noticed immediately. “Nora?”

Tomas looked at her.

Nora gripped the doorframe.

“Pressure,” she said.

Maya went pale.

“From who?”

Nora’s eyes moved before she could stop them.

Lucia.

Sleeping.

Tomas followed her gaze.

The room changed.

He understood something. Not the whole impossible truth, perhaps, but enough to know that Nora was standing at an edge.

“Do not,” he said.

The words were weak.

Absolute.

Nora looked at him.

Tomas’s eyes were sharp with exhaustion and command.

“Whatever this is,” he said, each word slow, “do not go into my wife’s fear.”

Maya went very still.

Nora’s throat closed.

“I’m trying not to.”

“Try harder.”

The phrase might have been cruel from someone else.

From Tomas, it was an anchor.

Nora pressed her back against the wall.

The pressure grew.

Lucia's sleeping face blurred.

Nora could feel it: the pull toward a wife's private terror, toward the night she had almost lost him, toward years of marriage condensed into dread.

She wanted to know.

No.

She wanted to help.

No.

She wanted the panic-dog to stop barking.

Tomas lifted his hand from the blanket.

It shook.

Maya grabbed it.

He kept his eyes on Nora.

"She is mine to comfort," he said.

The words broke the pull.

Not because they were romantic.

Because they were boundary.

A door closing from the inside.

Nora gasped.

The pressure vanished so suddenly her knees weakened.

Maya caught her before she could slide down the wall.

Lucia woke with a start. “What happened?”

“Nothing,” Tomas said quickly.

Everyone looked at him.

He sighed. “Fine. Something. But now nothing.”

Lucia frowned. “You are impossible.”

“Yes,” he said. “And beloved.”

Nora laughed once, breathlessly, then covered her face.

Maya held her elbow.

“You stayed,” Maya whispered.

Nora nodded, shaking.

Tomas leaned back against the pillow, exhausted by his own authority.

“Good,” he said. “Now someone bring me water. I have performed heroism.”

Lucia rolled her eyes and poured it for him.

Her hands trembled.

But they were hers.

Her fear remained hers.

That mattered so much Nora almost could not bear it.

Later, in the hallway, Nora sat on a plastic chair with her head against the wall.

Maya sat beside her.

Neither spoke for a while.

Then Maya said, “My father knows something is happening.”

“Yes.”

“Did Adam tell him?”

“No.”

“Did you?”

“No.”

Maya nodded slowly.

“He feels rooms,” she said.

Nora looked at her.

Maya smiled sadly. “He always has. When I was little, I thought he was magic because he knew when I was lying before I said anything.”

“Maybe you inherited that.”

“Maybe that’s why I recognized you.”

Nora’s throat tightened.

Maya leaned her head back against the wall.

“Did you want to go into my mother?”

Nora closed her eyes.

“Yes.”

Maya inhaled.

“I’m sorry.”

“No.” Maya’s voice was strained but steady. “No. Wanting is not taking.”

Nora opened her eyes.

Maya was looking straight ahead, tears slipping silently down her face.

“I’m repeating it because I need to believe it too,” she said.

Nora reached for her hand.

Stopped.

Maya noticed and took it herself.

They sat in the hallway holding hands while hospital life moved around them: nurses, carts, footsteps, a child crying somewhere far away, machines chiming softly behind closed doors.

So many doors.

So much fear.

Not all of it hers.

Not all of it asking.

When Nora left the hospital that evening, Lucia hugged her again.

Tomas lifted two fingers in farewell and said, “No pears next time.”

“Apples?” Nora asked.

“Acceptable.”

“Bananas?”

“Suspicious.”

“Noted.”

Maya walked her to the elevator.

At the doors, she hugged Nora fiercely.

“Thank you,” she said.

“For what?”

“For not knowing.”

The words entered Nora deeper than any praise.

The elevator opened.

Nora stepped inside.

As the doors closed, she saw Maya standing in the hallway, tired, afraid, and still somehow trusting her enough to turn away first.

Nora rode down alone.

For once, she did not feel abandoned by what she had not been told.

She felt entrusted with the mercy of not knowing.

Outside, evening had softened the sky.

Adam waited near the entrance, hands in his coat pockets.

Nora stopped when she saw him.

“You didn’t say you were coming.”

“I didn’t come up,” he said. “I thought I’d wait.”

She walked toward him.

The old part of her might have heard accusation in that. Might have heard distance. Might have heard him choosing the hallway again because she had become too complicated to enter fully.

But tonight, she heard something else.

Respect.

He had waited outside a room that was not his.

Just as she had.

Nora reached him and slipped her hand into his.

“No pressure?” he asked.

“No.”

“Good.”

They stood outside the hospital, hand in hand, while people came and went through the sliding doors.

“I didn’t go into Lucia,” Nora said.

Adam’s fingers tightened around hers.

“I know.”

“Maya told you?”

“No.” He looked at her. “You look like someone who won a fight no one saw.”

Nora leaned into him, tired suddenly beyond speech.

Adam wrapped one arm around her.

No jump came.

No door opened.

Behind them, the hospital glowed with rooms full of pain Nora would never know.

For the first time, that felt less like failure.

More like grace.

She did not have to enter every room to care that people were inside.

She did not have to know every fear to honor it.

And maybe the world had always been asking this of her, long before the jumps began:

Stand near.

Listen.

Wait to be invited.

Let some doors stay closed.

Nora closed her eyes against Adam’s coat.

Safe enough, she thought.

Not safe forever.

Not safe from pain.

But safe enough to leave a room untouched.

Safe enough to love without looking through the keyhole.

For that night, it was enough.

DaintyHub